

Assignment 1 - Storyboard

10/5/2025

15/15 Points

Attempt 2



Review Feedback

10/4/2025

Attempt 2 Score:

15/15

View Feedback

Anonymous Grading: **no**

Unlimited Attempts Allowed

9/24/2025 to 10/10/2025

▼ Details

Purpose

There will be five major deliverables for this course, each of which is designed to provide you with an opportunity to develop professional portfolio items. Each assignment will be outlined in greater detail on Canvas and will also be discussed in class. Creative interpretations of each assignment are encouraged!

Description

For Assignment 1, you will **prepare a storyboard** for a *human-centred data story related to a topical concern (e.g. the housing affordability crisis)*. Design sketches, prototypes, and notes are to be included in a notebook or document that shows various iterations and provides a rationale for design decisions. This assignment will be due on the same week as Class 5, and will be worth 15% of the final grade.

Instructions

This is what you're going to need to do for the assignment.

First, **identify a theme** that you'll find interesting. If you choose something related to affordability, you might focus on the preceding supply chain crisis, the effects of inflation, housing affordability, countries that have fared well (and why), or gen-z financial prospects. You might choose something personal if you've already been collecting data. Choose a theme that you would care to prepare a data story about.

Next, **figure out who or what the character(s) of your story will be**. Think about the readings from Week Three. Will your characters be people? Will they be things? How will you make your reader care about them?

Next, **select appropriate data** and familiarize yourself with it. Identify where you acquired it from and any steps you've taken to visualize it (or visualizations you've collected that draw from it). This is not a data analysis project, though. You DO NOT need to analyze data in detail or produce new charts. If

you do, that's fine, but the purpose of this assignment isn't to show off your analysis or visualization skills. You should be familiar with one or more datasets related to the topic you are storyboarding, so it won't hurt to do some very basic EDA, but you don't need to spend a bunch of time trying to visualize them. I want your time to be spent imagining interesting and engaging ways to tell the story with data.

Next, ***either create or find stand-in images of the charts/graphs/maps*** you would like your reader to explore. You can use AI-generated charts or ones you find from image searches. They are meant to demonstrate how you would use them in your story.

Next, you will need to ***identify an audience***. Who will your story be for? Make sure that is clear. Will they have the data literacy needed to understand your charts?

Finally, ***select an appropriate visualization-based storytelling method*** (e.g. infographic series; scrollytelling page; explainer video).

Script your story and lay it out using appropriate storyboarding techniques as demonstrated in class. You can either storyboard your narrative flow or the expected user interactions - or both.

Some protips:

- Try a few different approaches (i.e. use stickies; use paper-based sketches; use software).
- Balance text and visuals. A storyboard for a data story is different than what you'll find for a film. You are outlining the story and the media you'll use to tell it.
- Invest your time in a story that you will care about.
- Draw inspiration from related stories that you have read and heard. Recall compelling visualizations you have seen over the past year.

You will need to write approximately 7 paragraphs of notes that describe your work. Intro and rationale. Description of your method and/or techniques. Descriptions of iterations 1/2/3. Description of your audience. Concluding thoughts. Your goal will be to "highlight the human" in the narrative. In doing so, you'll also need to think about what you expect of your reader/audience? What do you want them to know or find out?

Evaluation

Your submission will be evaluated according to these criteria:

- ***Creativity (5)***: Creative interpretations of this assignment are highly encouraged! You can imagine animated scenes, video game-based stories, a comic book, etc. You can script a fictional narrative. You can use wild colour schemes. Present your work in a way that might be compelling to a new audience.
- ***Structure and Quality (5)***: Make sure your document is structured in a way that is logical and intuitive. While you are not expected to publish the results of this assignment, you should be thinking about this as a portfolio piece. As such, what you present should be clear, concise, and

well-written. Make sure to proofread for grammar and spelling mistakes. And absolutely make sure to put your name on your submission!

- *Audience (5)*: You must clearly articulate who your audience is and what insights you would like them to get from your data story. In other words, be clear about who your work is for, and use language and imagery that is appropriate for that group. A group of doctors is a very different audience than a twitter mob.

Resources

- Review the Pages that have been posted so far.
- Here are three examples of excellent submission from last year: [A1_Example1.pdf](https://learn.ontariotechu.ca/courses/35795/files/5498873?wrap=1) (<https://learn.ontariotechu.ca/courses/35795/files/5498873?wrap=1>)_ ↓
(https://learn.ontariotechu.ca/courses/35795/files/5498873/download?download_frd=1)
[A1_Example2.pdf](https://learn.ontariotechu.ca/courses/35795/files/5498872?wrap=1) (<https://learn.ontariotechu.ca/courses/35795/files/5498872?wrap=1>)_ ↓
(https://learn.ontariotechu.ca/courses/35795/files/5498872/download?download_frd=1)
[A1_Example3.pdf](https://learn.ontariotechu.ca/courses/35795/files/5498871?wrap=1) (<https://learn.ontariotechu.ca/courses/35795/files/5498871?wrap=1>)_ ↓
(https://learn.ontariotechu.ca/courses/35795/files/5498871/download?download_frd=1)
- <https://medium.com/nightingale/is-your-data-story-actually-a-story-3d1fa52394d9>
- <https://medium.com/nightingale/from-storytelling-to-scrollytelling-a-short-introduction-and-beyond-fbda32066964> (<https://medium.com/nightingale/from-storytelling-to-scrollytelling-a-short-introduction-and-beyond-fbda32066964>)
- Lena Groeger's piece about "small details" should be read again and again:
<https://www.propublica.org/nerds/a-big-article-about-wee-things>
(<https://www.propublica.org/nerds/a-big-article-about-wee-things>)
- Susie Lu on storytelling in dashboards: <https://www.susielu.com/data-viz/storytelling-in-dashboards> (<https://www.susielu.com/data-viz/storytelling-in-dashboards>)

Some Good Data Stories (for Context)

- <https://projects.thestar.com/climate-change-global-species-shakeup/>
(<https://projects.thestar.com/climate-change-global-species-shakeup/>)
- <https://www.nytimes.com/interactive/2020/07/23/magazine/climate-migration.html>
(<https://www.nytimes.com/interactive/2020/07/23/magazine/climate-migration.html>)
- <https://www.motherjones.com/politics/2020/09/greatschools-testing-segregation/>
(<https://www.motherjones.com/politics/2020/09/greatschools-testing-segregation/>)
- <https://abevoelker.com/2019-03-06/on-the-death-of-my-familys-dairy-farm/>
(<https://abevoelker.com/2019-03-06/on-the-death-of-my-familys-dairy-farm/>)
- <https://highline.huffingtonpost.com/articles/en/poor-millennials/>
(<https://highline.huffingtonpost.com/articles/en/poor-millennials/>)
- <https://www.nytimes.com/interactive/2019/12/19/opinion/location-tracking-cell-phone.html>
(<https://www.nytimes.com/interactive/2019/12/19/opinion/location-tracking-cell-phone.html>)
- <https://xujunjiejack.github.io/> (<https://xujunjiejack.github.io/>)

- <https://www.washingtonpost.com/graphics/2018/national/us-mexico-border-flyover/>
(<https://www.washingtonpost.com/graphics/2018/national/us-mexico-border-flyover/>)

File Name		Size	
	Assignmen...ted-1.pdf	1.62 MB	Download (https://learn.ontariotechu.ca/files/5550393/download?download_frd=1&verifier=jg5BAWA3wH1SzWu6Y9sHhw)



Page

<

 1

>

 of 26

—

 ZOOM

+

↗



